

Phishers commonly use misspelt URLs to trick users into believing that the site that the e-mail will direct you to is the actual site of the company they are posing as. Another telltale sign is the use of the “@” symbol in links: you might find something like “<http://www.ebay.in@geocities.com/>”. This spoofing method can easily deceive a casual observer who may not pay too much attention to the URLs he is being directed to.

Again, clever phishers will send HTML-based e-mails that look like plain text e-mails, so they can disguise the URL locations effectively. A quick way to fix this is to disable the HTML viewing option in your e-mail client.

6.2.3 But What (And How) Do Phishers Transmit?

Phishers can’t be everywhere at all times. So, like good thieves, they get their work done for them. The e-mail medium is the most commonly used, with phishers sending out thousands of malicious e-mails every single hour of every single day. But phishers aren’t the only ones sending out such mails. Increasingly, the sources of such mails are becoming home computers that have been compromised by and for phishing activities.

Here’s where Trojan Horses (see box *Trojan Horses*) come into the picture. Through various ways (spam, spyware, etc.), phishers install Trojans on unsuspecting home PC users. These computers then become partly (or in some serious cases, wholly) controlled by the phisher who uses the host computer’s e-mail client as a mes-

Trojan Horses

A Trojan Horse, or simply a Trojan (the name is derived from Greek mythology) is a malicious program that disguises itself as something interesting, thereby gaining the confidence of the user, who unsuspectingly then installs a piece of malicious software on his computer. Trojans are generally disguised as free screensavers and such, and they arouse the curiosity of those who they are sent to (usually by e-mail). Once installed, the developer of the Trojan is able to gain content from the machine(s) it has been installed on, which can then be used for malicious purposes.